The Book of Mormon and DNA

The Belief Files

Case File 005

Historical investigation and biblical assessment

Beyond the Message | LDS origins and authority | November 2026

Investigation summary

The Book of Mormon presents migrations from the ancient Near East to the Americas as real events. Genetic research investigates a different but related question: how the ancestors of Indigenous peoples of the Americas were connected to earlier populations. This case asks what happens when a religious ancestry claim is compared with the evidence from living people and ancient remains. [1–8]

The studies reviewed strongly support deep ancestral connections with ancient populations of Siberia and northeast Asia, including ancestry related to ancient northern Eurasians. They do not establish the Book of Mormon's named migrations. At the same time, a genetic test cannot identify every person in a remote family tree or conclusively exclude every small migration. The strength of an objection depends on the size, place, date, and genetic contribution proposed for the migrating group. [6–13]

The central finding is therefore specific. A model in which recent Near Eastern migrants supplied the principal ancestry of Indigenous peoples across the Americas faces substantial difficulty from these data. A small population absorbed into existing communities is harder to test. Making that smaller model possible does not demonstrate that Lehi or another named Book of Mormon figure lived. Neither conclusion independently establishes whether Joseph Smith knowingly invented the narrative.

The claim under investigation

The religious claim includes an ancient narrative, its modern presentation, and an explanation of why identifying its descendants might be difficult. These should not be treated as a single proposition.

- The narrative places Lehi in Jerusalem during the reign of Zedekiah and describes his family's journey to a promised land reached by sea. [4–5]
- The current introduction identifies the Lamanites as being among the ancestors of the American Indians. This is a narrower ancestry formulation than the older principal ancestors wording discussed in the supplied research. [1–3]
- The Church's DNA essay argues that unknown founder profiles, other populations, genetic drift, population losses, and later mixing can prevent detection of the reported migrants. [1–2]
- A further claim concerns authority: that the book is ancient scripture translated through Smith, rather than a nineteenth-century work given an ancient setting. Genetics addresses parts of the historical setting; it does not directly test inspiration or the quality of a religious experience.

This investigation does not assume that all LDS people hold one geography or population model. It also does not use genetic similarity to decide anyone's cultural identity, tribal membership, dignity, or religious worth. The question is what specified historical claims predict and how those predictions compare with the sources reviewed.

How this investigation weighs evidence

Define a prediction before judging a result. A claim about the primary ancestry of two continents is different from a claim about a small family in an unspecified region. A meaningful test needs enough detail to connect the proposed event with a likely observation.

Distinguish genetic ancestry from a family tree. An ancestor can occupy a place in a person's genealogy without contributing an identifiable segment of DNA to that person today. The two forms of ancestry overlap but are not interchangeable. [11]

Compare different kinds of genetic evidence. Mitochondrial DNA follows one maternal line; the Y chromosome follows one paternal line in those who inherit it. Genome-wide studies examine many more inherited segments. Failure to find a marker in one lineage is not the same test as a genome-wide comparison. [6, 11]

Give ancient samples their proper value and limits. A dated ancient individual provides evidence from before later population mixing. That improves the test but does not make a few sampled individuals representative of every community or every century. [7, 10, 13]

Separate a possible explanation from a demonstrated event. Genetic drift is real. Its existence does not identify a lost Book of Mormon lineage. Conversely, a missing lineage does not prove that every person said to carry it was imaginary. Assess the particular inference rather than choosing a slogan.

The historical timeline

Date or period	Record or research	Why it matters
Around 600 BC in the narrative	Lehi's account begins in the setting of Jerusalem and later describes an ocean journey. [3–5]	This is the claimed setting, not an independently dated migration record.
1830	The Book of Mormon is published through Joseph Smith. [1]	The narrative becomes available for public examination.
2006 update described by the Church	The introduction adopts the among the ancestors formulation. [2–3]	The extent of the ancestry claim must be distinguished from the narrative itself.
2014	Studies examine the ancient Mal'ta and Anzick genomes. [7–8]	Ancient data illuminate ancestry that predates the narrated migrations.
2015	Raghavan and colleagues compare ancient and modern genome-wide data. [6]	The investigation extends beyond a single maternal or paternal marker.
2016	Llamas and colleagues study ancient South American mitochondrial genomes. [10]	The record includes lineages no longer represented in the modern comparison data.
2018	Additional ancient genomes reveal complex regional population histories. [9, 13]	A simple picture of one unchanged population is insufficient.
2025 and 2026	Larger genome studies add data from North Asia and the Americas. [19–20]	The comparison includes research published after the original LDS essay.

Exhibit one The ancestry claim

Read the Book of Mormon's introduction separately from the narrative passages. The introduction describes the book's religious status, civilizations, and relationship to the ancestry of American Indians. First Nephi gives a particular family history within the narrative. These are different kinds of text, and a change to an editorial introduction should not be described as a discovered ancient manuscript variant. [3–5]

The Church's essay dates its introduction update to 2006 and points out that other populations could have lived in the Americas. The supplied packet compares the former principal ancestors wording with the current among the ancestors wording. This case verifies the current introduction and the Church's account of the update; it does not claim to have independently compared every printed edition. [1–3]

The distinction changes the evidential target. A population that supplies most of a continent's ancestry should have different genetic consequences from a small group that enters an already populated region. Any assessment of a narrowed model should identify its assumptions openly: where the group lived, approximately how many people were involved, how it mixed with others, and what descendants are being proposed.

A change in formulation raises an appropriate historical question about earlier teaching and later interpretation. It does not, by itself, establish why the change was made or what an individual leader privately believed. Nor should an earlier broad interpretation simply disappear from the investigation because a more limited explanation is now available.

Exhibit two The genetic findings

The evidence reviewed does not point to a predominantly recent Near Eastern origin for Indigenous peoples across the Americas. Raghavan and colleagues' 2015 study uses ancient and modern genome-wide data to model deep connections with Siberian ancestors and subsequent diversification. The paper's particular timing and migration model should be read as a research result rather than a permanently final account of every movement into the Americas. [6]

Two ancient individuals help clarify the timescale. The Anzick infant from Montana lived approximately 12,600 years ago and shows close genetic relationships with Indigenous American populations. The approximately 24,000-year-old Mal'ta individual from Siberia helps explain an ancient northern Eurasian contribution to Native American ancestry. These findings concern population history far earlier than Lehi's narrated departure. [7–8]

The Mal'ta result is especially important when discussing western Eurasian affinity. A broad genetic connection with western Eurasia is not automatically evidence for a migration from Jerusalem around 600 BC. The date, population relationship, and route of transmission matter. An ancient component shared through Siberian ancestors cannot simply be relabeled Israelite because some related ancestry also occurs farther west. [8]

The 2018 study by Moreno-Mayar and colleagues sequenced fifteen ancient genomes from Alaska to Patagonia and reported a dynamic pattern of dispersal and diversification. Posth and colleagues examined forty-nine ancient individuals from Central and South America across several regional time transects. These studies complicate a picture of one uniform population. They do not identify Nephites or Lamanites through independently established genetic reference samples. [9, 13]

More recent work reinforces the need for a detailed model. A 2025 study by Gusareva and colleagues reports genomes from 1,537 individuals across 139 groups in North Asia and South America. A 2026 Nature study adds 128 high-coverage Indigenous American genomes and reports evidence for at least three dispersals into South America, regional differentiation, and

long-term continuity. These results describe variation and movements within a deep population history. They do not identify a named Book of Mormon migration. [19–20]

This case is a comparison of identified studies, including research published in 2025 and 2026, rather than an exhaustive review of all genetics. Its main conclusion does not depend on claiming that one paper has settled every route or date. Multiple data sets support a deep population history that a broad recent-origin model must account for.

Exhibit three What can remain undetected

Mechanism or limitation	What it means	What it does not establish
Founder effect	A small founding group carries only part of its parent population's variation. [12]	That a particular unidentified founder came from Jerusalem.
Genetic drift	Random inheritance can change marker frequencies or eliminate variants. [14]	That drift erased a specific Book of Mormon marker.
Population loss	Some lineages can disappear when communities lose members or die out. [10]	That the missing lineages belonged to a named religious population.
Genealogical ancestry	A family-tree ancestor need not leave identifiable DNA in every later descendant. [11]	That a genealogical relationship has been demonstrated without other evidence.
Unknown reference group	There is no authenticated genome for Lehi's family available to this investigation. [1–2]	That any broadly similar modern genetic result identifies that family.

These limitations deserve serious treatment. Llamas and colleagues sequenced ninety-two ancient South American mitochondrial genomes. Their abstract reports that the ancient lineages detected were absent from the modern comparison data and links the pattern to high lineage loss after European colonization. This is relevant evidence that modern samples can miss formerly existing maternal lineages. It is not evidence identifying any of those lineages as Book of Mormon ancestry. [10]

Ancient DNA also limits a blanket appeal to later loss. Researchers can examine some individuals who lived before European arrival; their ancestry was not created by later colonial mixing. Yet the available ancient sample coverage remains incomplete. The responsible question is which proposed population, place, and date are actually represented, not whether ancient DNA makes every possible migration detectable. [7, 9–10, 13]

Different dating methods must also be distinguished. Dating the remains of an individual is not identical to estimating when that person's ancestors mixed. The ages of genetic branches are not automatically the dates when people crossed an ocean. This case does not calculate a detection probability or claim that all relevant dating problems have been solved.

Assessing the principal evidence

The witnesses in this investigation include researchers reporting measurements, editors describing a religious text, and believers explaining what they understand that text to claim. Those sources answer different questions.

Research papers can support conclusions about the sampled individuals and the models tested. Evaluate their sample coverage, the kind of DNA examined, dates, comparison groups, and uncertainty. An abstract is sufficient for reporting its stated broad result; it is not a substitute for a specialist audit of the raw data and supplements. The register identifies where this case relies on an abstract. [6–13]

The current introduction and Church essay establish how the Church presently frames the ancestry question and what limitations it invokes. Their

religious authority does not independently establish the migration. A scientist's discussion of drift likewise does not endorse every religious application made of that mechanism. [2–3, 12, 14]

The narrative itself establishes what the book says happened. It is the claim under examination, not independent corroboration of its own setting. Naming a family and an ocean voyage cannot supply the missing genetic reference sample. [4–5]

Personal testimony may explain a reader's conviction and deserves an accurate hearing. It is not a population-genetic measurement. A Christian should apply the same distinction to personal experiences offered in support of Christianity.

The strongest assessment combines sources without asking one kind of evidence to do another's job. Genetics can challenge a population model while leaving its advocates to defend a narrower one. That does not remove the need for affirmative historical reasons to accept the narrower claim.

The strongest LDS argument

The strongest defense avoids claiming that DNA has identified Lehi. It argues that a small group could have entered a much larger population, that its genetic profile is unknown, and that later inheritance and population loss could obscure its descendants. The book's religious purpose and a reader's spiritual witness would then be evaluated alongside other evidence. [1–2, 15]

Several premises are sound in principle. Founding groups may be genetically unrepresentative; variants can disappear; and genetic ancestry is not a complete family tree. A critic who dismisses these mechanisms as imaginary weakens the criticism. [11–12, 14]

The unresolved issue is the application. To move from possibility to historical support requires reasons to favor this particular small-group migration: an adequately defined location and population history, independent evidence, and predictions that can be compared with

observations. The genetic mechanisms do not select the Book of Mormon explanation from every other small migration that could be proposed.

Competing explanations

A broad ancestry model

Recent Near Eastern migrants became the principal ancestral source of Indigenous peoples throughout the Americas. The deep relationships and ancient samples reviewed here create serious difficulty for that model. Defining principal precisely and specifying the populations involved would be necessary for a quantitative test. [6–10, 13]

A small migration absorbed into existing populations

A group comparable to the narrative's founders arrived among much larger established communities. Some genealogical descendants might survive while a recognizable genetic signal became difficult to detect. This is possible in principle. The studies reviewed do not establish that the proposed named group existed or determine its location.

A nineteenth century religious narrative

The migration history was constructed in Smith's era rather than translated from an authentic ancient record. The absence of a demonstrated Book of Mormon genetic population is compatible with that explanation. Compatibility alone does not establish the work's detailed composition history or Smith's knowledge and intent. Those questions also require documentary and textual investigation.

A religious reading that does not depend on literal migration

Some readers may value the work spiritually while treating its setting differently from a literal ancient history. That approach changes the historical claim under discussion. It should not be presented as identical to the Church's stated account of real migrations and translation. Whether such a reading is religiously acceptable is a further theological question. [2–3]

The possibilities are not equally supported simply because all can be stated. A useful next step is to ask what evidence each explanation predicts, what would count against it, and which assumptions are introduced specifically to accommodate a difficult result.

Motives benefits and costs

An ancestry narrative can connect faith with family, identity, land, and belonging. That gives the question personal significance. It does not make a believer's motives suspect, and it does not change the standards for establishing a historical migration.

Institutions and critics both have reasons to favor interpretations consistent with their existing commitments. Such incentives are reasons to scrutinize arguments, not proof of dishonesty. There is no genetic measurement that establishes whether Smith consciously deceived readers.

For a Christian conversation, the person matters alongside the claim. Explain the population model being tested before presenting a result as if it invalidates someone's whole family story. Careful definitions make a disagreement more precise and a conversation more useful.

A biblical assessment

Faith and events in history

Luke 1:1-4 presents an account concerned with received testimony and careful narration. First Corinthians 15:3-19 grounds Christian proclamation in Christ's death, burial, resurrection, and appearances; Paul states that the faith would fail if Christ had not been raised. From this project's Christian perspective, a spiritual purpose does not remove the significance of historical truth. [16–17]

That principle applies to Christian claims as well. Paul's report about a large group of witnesses is one surviving report, not hundreds of separately preserved depositions. The resurrection requires its own historical

investigation. A difficulty for a Book of Mormon population model is not, by itself, evidence that the resurrection happened.

Testing teaching and spiritual testimony

Acts 17:11 commends examination of teaching in relation to Scripture. First John 4:1-3 calls for testing spiritual claims, and Galatians 1:6-9 makes the content of the proclaimed gospel central even when a heavenly messenger is invoked. The Christian assessment therefore asks what a testimony affirms and how that teaching relates to the apostolic message. [16, 18]

Moroni 10:3-5 connects prayer with remembrance, sincerity, faith in Christ, and the Holy Ghost. Reducing that practice to a casual good feeling would misrepresent it. Christians can acknowledge its seriousness while disagreeing that an inward conviction independently establishes a proposed population history or overrides a substantive disagreement about the gospel. [15]

Honest weights and truthful witness

Proverbs 18:13 and 18:17 warn against answering before hearing and against accepting an unexamined first account. Ephesians 4:25 calls believers to speak truthfully. These passages do not teach genetics, but they do require Christians to state scientific conclusions accurately and listen to the strongest response. [18]

The warranted Christian argument is that religious historical claims remain open to examination and that claims to revelation must be tested. It is not that DNA proves Christianity, that every ancient ancestor is recoverable, or that every LDS person knowingly ignores evidence.

Findings and confidence

Confidence refers to the stated finding and the sources reviewed, not a numerical probability assigned to inspiration.

Finding	Confidence	Basis and limit
Deep Siberian and northeast Asian connections are documented.	High	Multiple ancient and modern studies; details of migration models continue to develop. [6–9, 13]
Ancient northern Eurasian ancestry establishes Lehi's migration.	Not established	The ancient component predates the narrated migration by many millennia. [7–8]
Some ancestral lineages can become undetectable.	High	Inheritance mechanisms and evidence of lost maternal lineages. [10–12, 14]
The reviewed studies identify a named Book of Mormon population.	Not established	No authenticated founder reference or demonstrated identification in these studies.
DNA excludes every small migration or remote genealogical ancestor.	Not established	Detection depends on the model, sampling, and inheritance.
The genetic findings prove deliberate fraud by Smith.	Not established	Genetic evidence does not independently establish private intent.

Overall assessment

The reviewed genetic record creates a substantial problem for a broad model of predominantly recent Near Eastern ancestry across the Americas. That conclusion should not be softened into the idea that genetics tells us nothing. Ancient and modern genomes provide positive evidence for a much deeper population history. [6–10, 13]

The limitations invoked in a smaller LDS model are also real. They prevent a claim that every possible ancestor or tiny migration has been excluded. They do not turn missing or unidentified evidence into a demonstrated migration. A narrowed model needs affirmative support of its own.

From this project's evangelical and Trinitarian Christian perspective, the next issue is the authority of the text and its message about Christ. That assessment draws on Scripture and historical investigation together. This case leaves the reader with a defined evidential question rather than a claim that a single laboratory result has settled every religious issue.

Read compare and discuss

Read the present Book of Mormon introduction, 1 Nephi 1 and 18, and the Church's DNA essay. Compare the Anzick study's abstract and the explanations of founder effect and drift. Then read Luke 1:1-4 and 1 Corinthians 15:3-19. Keep three columns of notes: the claim, the observation, and the inference.

1. Are you evaluating principal population ancestry, a small migration, or one remote genealogical relationship?
2. What places, dates, and numbers would make the claim more testable?
3. Which result supplies positive evidence, and which only limits a possible objection?
4. What does a dated ancient sample add that a modern sample cannot supply?
5. Why does an ancient western Eurasian connection not automatically identify an Israelite migration?
6. What evidence would lead you to revise your own favored explanation?
7. How would you investigate a Christian historical claim with the same care?

A useful opening with an LDS friend is: "What ancestry claim do you understand the Book of Mormon to make?" A follow-up is: "If a small

group could be difficult to detect, what positive evidence leads you to identify that group with this narrative?" Allow a substantive response before explaining your Christian conviction.

For group or family study, compare a drawing of a family tree with the particular inherited lines represented by mitochondrial DNA. Explain that no small illustration captures an entire population history. The lesson is to distinguish kinds of evidence, not to perform an ancestry test or assign anyone an identity.

Accuracy notes and further research

- The supplied packet is a working synthesis. Its broad conclusions have been qualified using identified scientific and official sources. [1]
- The current introduction and the Church's description of its 2006 update were checked. A complete edition-by-edition history of the introduction remains separate research. [2–3]
- Genetic relationships with ancient northern Eurasians must not be described as direct identification of ancient Israelites. [7–8]
- Mitochondrial, Y-chromosome, and genome-wide findings are different measurements. Loss in one inherited line does not establish loss throughout an entire genome. [6, 11]
- The Llamas, Moreno-Mayar, and Posth results are summarized at the abstract level here. Their raw data, supplements, and statistical models have not been independently reanalyzed. [9–10, 13]
- This case supplies no calculated probability that Lehi's alleged descendants should be detected. Such a calculation would require a specified demographic model and specialist analysis.
- A comprehensive archaeological assessment, a complete study of Book of Mormon geography, and every early leader's ancestry statements fall outside this investigation.

Sources and reading

The register identifies supplied research, religious claims, scientific findings, and biblical comparison. Sources were checked November 8, 2026. Original analysis and theological conclusions are distinguished from the results reported by researchers.

[1] Supplied research. *LDS Gospel Topics Essays*, compiled 366-page project PDF, physical pages 1-31. The DNA source packet provides the initial claim inventory, comparison questions, and warnings requiring scientific verification. It is a working synthesis rather than an independent genetic study.

[2] Current LDS explanation. Book of Mormon and DNA Studies, Gospel Topics Essays. Source for the Church's account of the ancestry question, the introduction update, detection limitations, and the role of spiritual conviction. Its claims are evaluated alongside the research papers.

[3] Current introduction. Introduction to the Book of Mormon. Source for the current among the ancestors wording and the stated religious claims. This case does not present the introduction as a passage from the ancient narrative or claim direct inspection of every earlier edition.

[4] Narrative setting. 1 Nephi 1, especially verse 4. A source for the claimed setting in Jerusalem; its narrative date is distinguished from independently dated evidence.

[5] Narrative voyage. 1 Nephi 18, especially verses 8-25. Source for the narrated sea journey and arrival. The story is the historical claim under investigation, not separate corroboration of its own events.

[6] Genome-wide research. Raghavan and colleagues, Genomic evidence for the Pleistocene and recent population history of Native Americans, *Science* 349, aab3884 (2015), doi:10.1126/science.aab3884. Ancient and modern data support deep population relationships; the paper also distinguishes single-lineage evidence from genome-wide analysis.

[7] Ancient Anzick genome. Rasmussen and colleagues, The genome of a Late Pleistocene human from a Clovis burial site in western Montana, *Nature* 506, 225-229 (2014), doi:10.1038/nature13025. An approximately 12,600-year-old individual provides evidence predating European contact and the narrated Lehi migration.

[8] Ancient Siberian genome. Raghavan and colleagues, Upper Palaeolithic Siberian genome reveals dual ancestry of Native Americans, *Nature* 505, 87-91 (2014),

doi:10.1038/nature12736. Used to distinguish ancient northern Eurasian ancestry from a claimed later Near Eastern migration.

[9] Regional ancient genomes. Moreno-Mayar and colleagues, Early human dispersals within the Americas, *Science* 362, eaav2621 (2018), doi:10.1126/science.aav2621. The abstract reports fifteen ancient genomes and complex dispersal and diversification. This case uses that stated result without independently reanalyzing the study.

[10] Ancient maternal lineages. Llamas and colleagues, Ancient mitochondrial DNA provides high-resolution time scale of the peopling of the Americas, *Science Advances* 2, e1501385 (2016), doi:10.1126/sciadv.1501385. The author institution's abstract describes ninety-two ancient mitogenomes and loss of lineages in modern comparison data. This is evidence about maternal lineages, not every part of ancestry.

[11] Ancestry concepts. Mathieson and Scally, What is ancestry, *PLOS Genetics* 16, e1008624 (2020). A conceptual discussion distinguishing genealogical ancestry, genetic ancestry, and genetic similarity. It does not test the Book of Mormon.

[12] Scientific definition. National Human Genome Research Institute, Founder Effect. Official explanation of a mechanism by which a small founding population carries only part of a larger population's variation. Application to an unidentified historical family remains a separate inference.

[13] Additional regional research. Posth and colleagues, Reconstructing the Deep Population History of Central and South America, *Cell* 175, 1185-1197.e22 (2018), doi:10.1016/j.cell.2018.10.027. The published abstract describes forty-nine ancient individuals across four regional time transects. Used for that broad finding, not a claim of exhaustive regional sampling.

[14] Scientific definition. National Human Genome Research Institute, Genetic Drift. Explains random changes in allele frequencies, including loss of variants. It supplies a mechanism, not an identification of any Book of Mormon population.

[15] LDS spiritual test. Moroni 10:3-5, referenced in the current Book of Mormon introduction. The comparison acknowledges the passage's seriousness and its connection with faith in Christ; it does not reduce the practice to an unexplained pleasant feeling.

[16] Biblical historical method. KJV, Luke 1:1-4 and Acts 17:10-12. These passages inform the project's Christian understanding of testimony, careful inquiry, and examining teaching. They are not scientific accounts of population genetics.

[17] Biblical resurrection claim. KJV, 1 Corinthians 15:3-19. The comparison distinguishes Paul's surviving report from independently preserved statements by every person he mentions. The resurrection's historical evidence requires its own investigation.

[18] Biblical assessment and conduct. KJV, 1 John 4:1-3; Galatians 1:6-9; Proverbs 18:13, 17; Ephesians 4:25. Sources for the stated Christian theological and ethical assessment. Their implications are identified as the project's interpretation.

[19] Recent large genome study. Gusareva and colleagues, From North Asia to South America Tracing the longest human migration through genomic sequencing, *Science* 388, eadk5081 (2025), doi:10.1126/science.adk5081. The abstract reports 1,537 individuals from 139 groups. Used for its stated sample scope and broad population-history result, without independent reanalysis.

[20] Recent Indigenous American genomes. The evolutionary history and unique genetic diversity of Indigenous Americans, *Nature*, published April 22, 2026, doi:10.1038/s41586-026-10406-w. The abstract and population-history discussion describe 128 high-coverage genomes, regional differentiation, and multiple dispersals. A report of these broad findings is distinguished from an independent audit of the data and models.

Collection notes

Case File 005 follows Becoming Like God and precedes Priesthood Temples and Women. The collection begins with 00 and continues through Cases 001-012, followed by the separate Christian conversation guide. A planned case is not complete until its own research, preparation, and publication checks are finished.